

Co-design session planner

The structure I use to hand the pen over without losing the thread. Co-design is not a single workshop. It is a sustained partnership across an arc, where the people affected hold real decision-making power. This planner keeps that partnership rigorous.

Use this to plan a co-design engagement end to end. Work top to bottom: set the frame before you fill the sessions, and don't skip the closing-the-loop step, it is the part most often dropped and the part that most determines whether people trust you next time.

1. Frame the partnership

THE PROBLEM, IN THE COMMUNITY'S WORDS

WHAT IS GENUINELY OPEN TO CHANGE

WHAT IS FIXED (BE HONEST)

WHO HOLDS DECISION-MAKING POWER, AND OVER WHAT

2. Build the room

WHO IS MOST AFFECTED

HOW YOU'LL REACH THEM

SUPPORT THEY NEED TO TAKE PART

Reimburse people for their time and expertise as a default, not an exception. Lived experience is a contribution, not a favour.

3. The arc

Co-design moves through five stages. Each can be one session or several. Don't rush Frame and Explore to get to Build, the quality of the build depends on them.

Frame

Agree the problem and the boundaries together. Surface assumptions early.

Explore

Understand lived reality before proposing anything. What people experience, not what an instrument assumes.

Build

Generate the answer with the group. Prototype roughly. Let people change direction.

Test

Put the draft back in front of reality. What survives contact, what doesn't.

Decide

Make the call in the open, and show how the group's work shaped it.

4. Session plan

SESSION AIM (ONE SENTENCE)

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WHO IS HERE

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STAGE OF THE ARC

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SEQUENCE (HOW POWER STAYS BALANCED THROUGH THE SESSION)

.....
.....
.....

WHAT WE DECIDE BY THE END

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5. Facilitation principles

- Design the sequence so the loudest voice doesn't set the agenda.
- Hold the outcome loosely enough that it can genuinely change.
- Trust that the people closest to the problem know things the brief does not.
- Name discomfort when it appears. It usually marks the real question.
- Capture verbatim, not just themes. The words carry the meaning.

6. Close the loop

WHAT CHANGED BECAUSE OF THIS GROUP

HOW AND WHEN PARTICIPANTS WILL HEAR IT

THE PATIENT-CENTRED OUTCOME WE SET OUT TO MOVE, AND WHETHER IT MOVED

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